

Washes

Washes are the foundation of watercolor painting, as they are the first application of paint to the paper, whether as a tinted ground or a large painted area. Laying a wash, therefore, is a vital technique to

master. Once you have practiced producing a smooth, flat wash in a single color, you can vary the basic technique to create graded washes, variegated washes, and broken washes.

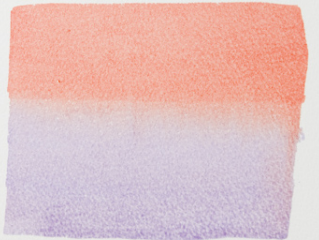
FLAT WASH

		
Dampen the paper and tilt your drawing board slightly. With a large flat brush, paint a band across the top of the paper.	Starting at the other side of the paper, paint the next band so that it overlaps the first. Repeat to the bottom of the paper. Dry with the paper tilted.	In a flat wash, the bands of paint blend together while they are still wet to create a smooth wash of uniform color.

GRADED WASH

		
Dampen the paper and lay a wash across the top. Immediately add water to the paint and add another band of paint at the base of the first band.	Add more water to your paint and repeat. Continue to dilute the paint for each band of paint, until you reach the bottom. Allow to dry.	A graded wash becomes progressively lighter toward the bottom, as each band of paint is more diluted than the previous one.

VARIEGATED WASH

			
Paint two bands of a wash at the top of the damp paper. Load your brush with a different color and paint this below the first color.	Let the bands of paint blend on the paper. To produce a more colorful result, introduce a different color with each new stroke.	Hold your brush low on the paper so that you drag the color over the surface, letting the paper's texture break up the bands of paint.	You can vary the position of the broken marks by letting the brush glance across the paper in different places to create texture.